He played compulsively, with a terrible desperation, attempting his trademark clipped shot at almost every delivery. He somehow made all nine runs in our fifteen-ball partnership before he directed a Mitchell Johnson bouncer to Nathan Lyon at deepish backward square leg. The gloom was deepening, literally and metaphorically.

It must have been horrendous for him. It is unthinkable that a game you love so much represents such a threat that you don't want to expose yourself to the battle. I know the analogy may grate in such sensitive circumstances, but that is what Test cricket is, a battle. For someone of his talent to shy away from the challenge he had confronted so well, so often, asked questions of us all.

We all balance competitive intensity and personal welfare. We all understand the parameters of professionalism. We all admit to ourselves that we occasionally exceed sensible levels of commitment. We all knew, instinctively, that Trotty was in a bad way. For that trip, at least, there was no way back. We lost by 381 runs on the fourth day, an ominous defeat. In retrospect the tour started to fall apart before it had barely begun.

Some people, who should have known better, said things that should have remained unsaid. Though, to his credit, he subsequently apologized for describing Trotty's second-innings dismissal as 'pretty poor and weak', the Aussie opener, David Warner, was utterly out of order in suggesting he typified a team playing with 'scared eyes'. He was rightly taken to task by Flower for such disparaging nonsense.

Andy told us in the dressing room that Trotty was flying home. His emotional response underlined the gravity of the situation. Here was a tough coach, an honourable man, who had demanded everything from the group for four or five years. The hard-edged persona he had adopted softened to reveal a sensitive soul who cared deeply for the well-being of the players under his control.

He spoke passionately, emotively and tenderly about events, and the nature of what we do. Trotty was not there and left without a formal farewell. The media were told it was due to a 'stress-related illness'. A captain in such a terrible situation is torn between his responsibility to the group and his duty of care to the individual. The squad is the rock, the stricken player is in a hard place.

I was obliged to sift through the wreckage of that Test match, in November 2013, for clues or slithers of encouragement. Australia weren't